



Inter-cultural Communication

HS-304

Business Communication and Ethics

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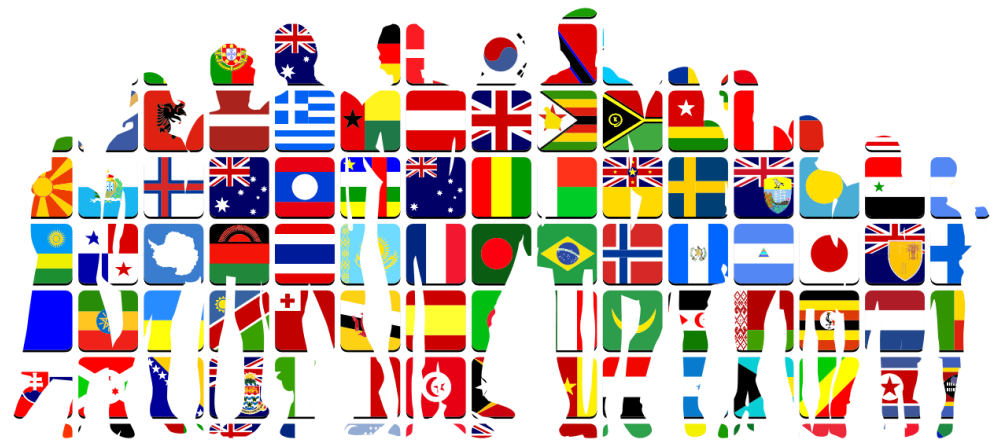
Intercultural Communication

Difference between Multicultural and Intercultural

The term **multicultural** refers to nations that have **diverse cultural groups**, usually as a result of immigration, while the term **intercultural** refers to the **diversity among separate nations**.

- Understanding the **role of culture in communication is an essential foundation** for understanding intercultural communication as it **occurs interpersonally, in small groups, in public speaking, or in the media.**
- Intercultural communication occurs **when the people creating shared meanings have different cultural perspectives and values.**
- Intercultural communication **may occur between individuals**; it occurs when you travel abroad and talk with someone in a culture that is different from your own.
- Intercultural communication **may also occur between groups of people or within nations.**
- It **also occurs** between and among **states**, often through global intergovernmental organizations like the United Nations.

Intercultural Communication



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How Cultures Differ?

There are at least **four major ways in which cultures differ that are especially important for communication**. These are:

1. Individual and Collective Orientation:

Cultures differ in the **extent to which they promote individual values** (for example, power, achievement, and stimulation) versus **collectivist values** (for example, benevolence, tradition, and conformity).

In an individualistic – oriented culture **members are responsible for themselves and perhaps for their immediate family**, whereas in a collectivist culture, **members are responsible for the entire group**.



How Cultures Differ?

2. High- and Low- Context Cultures:

A high-context culture is one in which much of the information in communication is in the context or in the person – for example, information that was shared through previous communications, through assumptions about each other, and through shared experiences.

Members of high-context cultures spend lots of time getting to know each other interpersonally and socially before any important transactions take place. They place emphasis on face-saving, and are reluctant to say no for fear of offending the other person.

A low-context culture is one in which most of the information is explicitly stated in the verbal message. Low-context cultures are also individualistic cultures. They spend less time getting to know each other and hence don't have the shared knowledge. As a result, everything has to be explicitly stated.

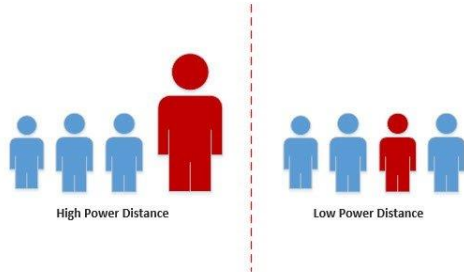


How Cultures Differ?

3. Power Distances:

In some cultures power is concentrated in the hands of a few, and there is a great difference in the power held by these people and by the ordinary citizen. These are called **high power distance cultures**. Direct confrontation and assertiveness may be viewed negatively, especially if directed at a superior. In high power distance cultures, there is a great power distance between students and teachers; students are expected to be modest, polite, and totally respectful.

In low power distance cultures, power is more evenly distributed throughout the citizenry. In **low power distance cultures** you're expected to confront a friend or supervisor assertively; there is in these cultures a general feeling of equality which is consistent with acting assertively.



How Cultures Differ?

4. Masculine and Feminine Cultures:

In a highly masculine culture, **men are viewed as assertive**, oriented to material success, and strong; **women are viewed as modest**, focused on the quality of life, and tender.

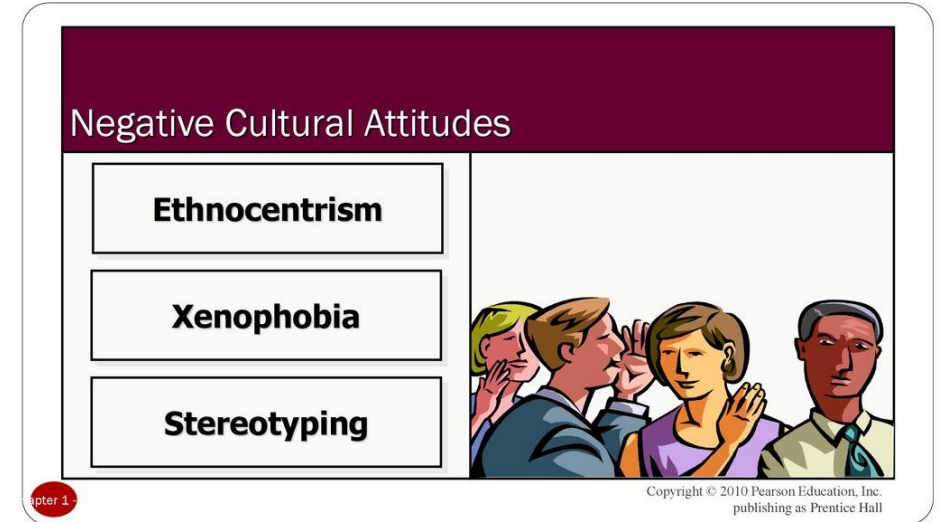
Members of masculine cultures are more likely to **confront conflicts directly** and to competitively fight out any differences; they are **more likely to emphasize win-lose conflict strategies**.

In a highly feminine culture, both **men and women are encouraged to be modest**. Oriented to maintain the quality of life, and tender. Feminine cultures are more likely to **emphasize compromise and negotiation in resolving conflicts**.



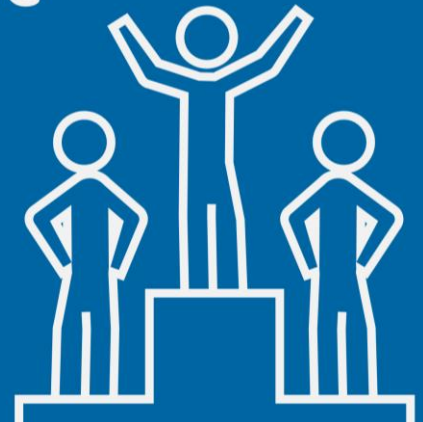
Factors Affecting/block Intercultural Communication

- **Ethnocentrism**
- **Prejudice**
- **Stereotyping**
- **Discrimination**



ethnocentric

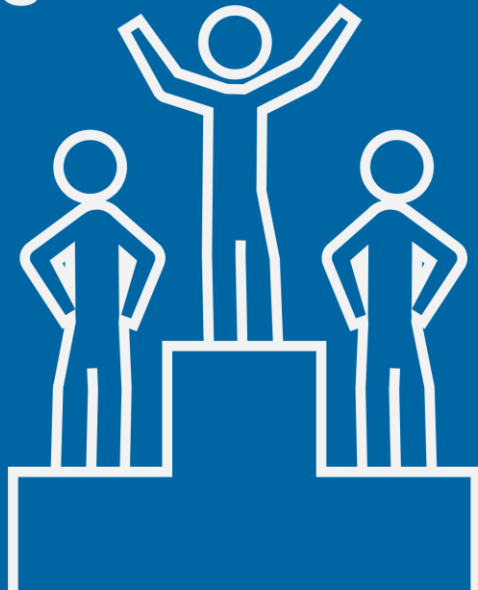
*thinking your
own culture is
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another culture*



Factors Affecting/block Intercultural Communication

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- **Ethnocentrism**

Ethnocentrism is the use of **one's own culture and its practices as the standard for interpreting the values, beliefs, norms, and communication of other cultures.**

Ethnocentrism fosters negative judgments of anything that differs from our own ways.

Factors Affecting Intercultural Communication



- **Prejudice**

Prejudice means decision making on the basis of incomplete information or pre-judging. It is a subjective attitude, opinion, or feeling formed without prior knowledge, thought, or objective reason.



- **Stereotyping**

A stereotype is a method of understanding, which works through classifying individual people into a group category. As a typical picture about a social group, a stereotype may be accurate or inaccurate, justified or unjustified. It is though, the negative, the inaccurate, and the unjustified stereotypes that distort the communication.



- **Discrimination**

Discrimination is the differential treatment that favours one individual, group, or object over another.

When you have a conversation with someone from another culture, you can reduce misunderstandings by following these tips:

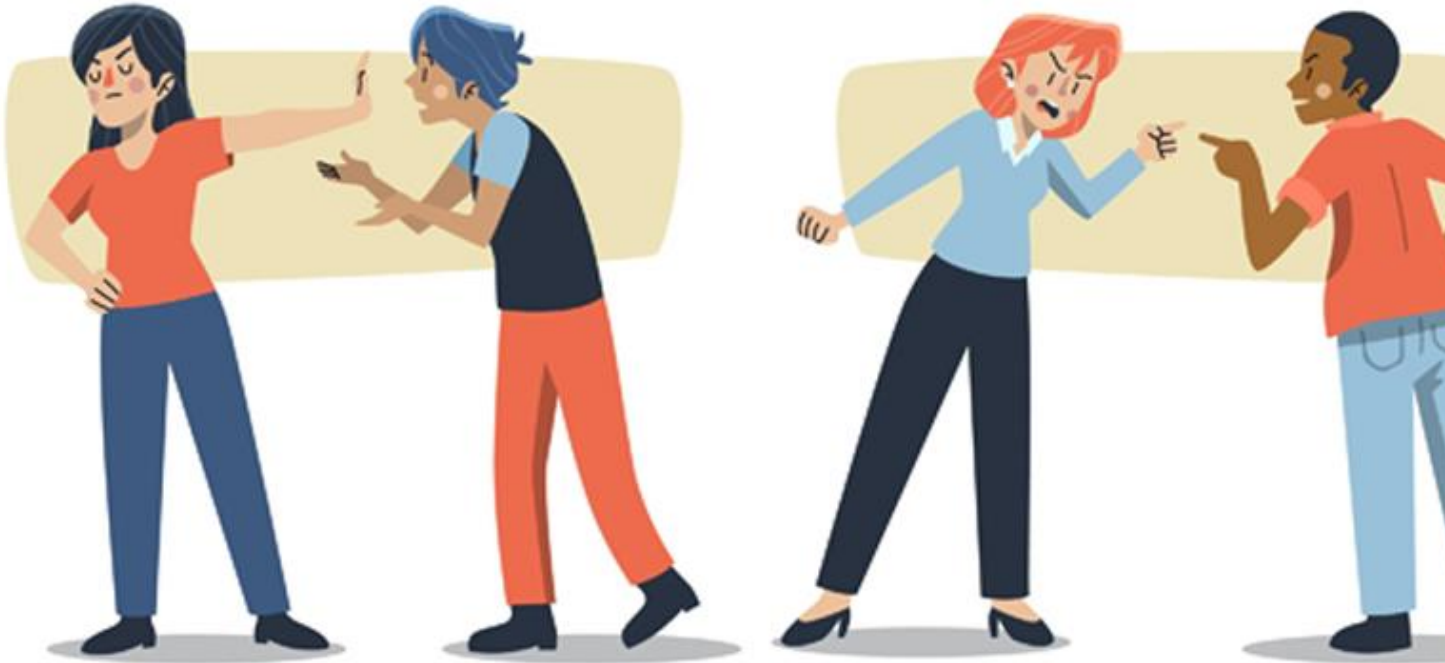
Use simple English:

- Speak in short sentences (**under 20 words**) with familiar, short words.
- **Eliminate puns, sports and military references, slang, and jargon (special business terms).**
- Be **especially alert to idiomatic expressions** that can't be translated, such as burn the midnight oil and under the weather.
- **Speak slowly and enunciate clearly.**
- Avoid fast speech, but don't raise your voice. Over punctuate with pauses and full stops.

How to Minimize Oral Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences



How to Minimize Oral Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences



Encourage accurate feedback:

- Ask probing questions, and encourage the listener to paraphrase what you say.
- Don't assume that a yes, a nod, or a smile indicates comprehension or assent.

How to Minimize Oral Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences

Check frequently for comprehension:

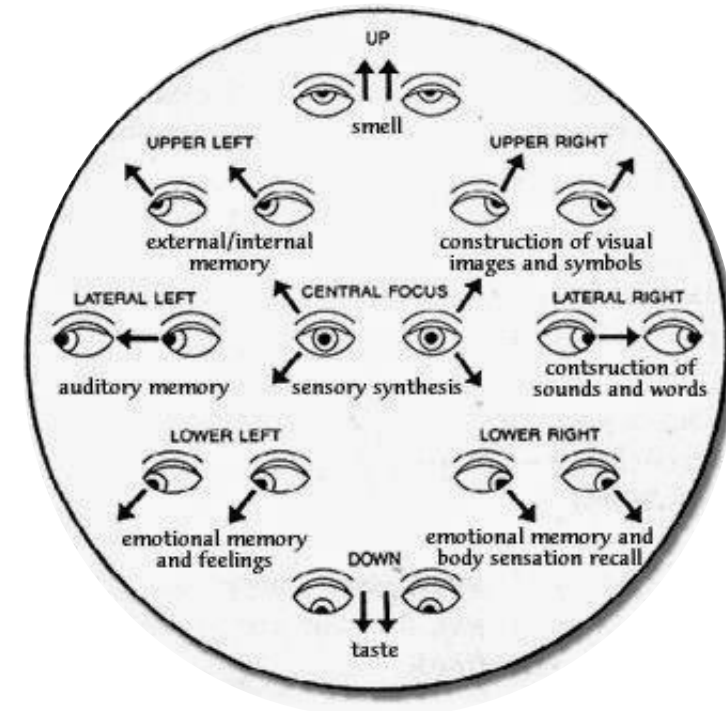
Avoid waiting until you finish a long explanation to request feedback. Instead, make one point at a time, pausing to check for comprehension. Don't proceed to B until A has been grasped.

Observe eye messages.

Be alert to a glazed expression or wandering eyes. These tell you the listener is lost.

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How to Minimize Oral Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences



Accept blame.

If a misunderstanding results, graciously accept the blame for not making your meaning clear.

Listen without interrupting.

Curb your desire to finish sentences or to fill out ideas for the speaker. Keep in mind that North Americans abroad are often accused of listening too little and talking too much.



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Smile when appropriate

Roger Axtell, international behavior expert, calls the smile the single most understood and most useful form of communication in either personal or business transactions. In some cultures, however, excessive smiling may seem insincere.

Follow up in writing

After conversations or oral negotiations, confirm the results and agreements with follow-up letters. For proposals and contracts, engage a qualified translator to prepare copies in the local language.



How to Minimize Written Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences

Written Intercultural Skills



- ✓ Use Plain English
- ✓ Strive for Clarity
- ✓ Use Proper Addresses
- ✓ Cite Numbers Carefully

How to Minimize Written Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences

When you write to someone from a different culture, you can improve your chances of being understood by following these suggestions:

Consider local styles:

Learn how documents are formatted and how letters are addressed and developed in the intended reader's country. Decide whether to use your organization's preferred format or adjust to local styles.

Consider hiring a translator:

Engage a professional translator if (a) your document is important, (b) your document will be distributed to many readers, or (c) you must be persuasive.





How to Minimize Written Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences

Use short sentences and short paragraphs.

Sentences with fewer than 20 words and paragraphs with fewer than 8 lines are most readable.

Avoid ambiguous wording.

Include relative pronouns (that, which, who) for clarity in introducing clauses. Stay away from contractions (especially ones such as Here's the problem). Avoid idioms (once in a blue moon), slang (my presentation really bombed), acronyms (ASAP for as soon as possible), abbreviations (DBA for doing business as), and jargon (input, output, clickstream). Use action-specific verbs (purchase a printer rather than get a printer).

How to Minimize Written Miscommunication Among Intercultural Audiences

Cite numbers carefully

For international trade it is a good idea to learn and use the metric system. In citing numbers, use figures (15) instead of spelling them out (fifteen).

Always convert dollar figures into local currency. Avoid using figures to express the month of the year.

In North America, for example, March 5, 2009, might be written as 3/5/09, while in Europe the same date might appear as 5.3.09.

For clarity, always spell out the month.



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